CHAPTER 2

# ABERRATIONS OF LIGHT

If man were taken away from the world, the rest would seem to be all astray, without aim or purpose … and to be leading to nothing.

—FRANCIS BACON, *WISDOM OF THE ANCIENTS* (1619)

Ann Druyan suggests an experiment: Look back again at the pale blue dot of the preceding chapter. Take a good long look at it. Stare at the dot for any length of time and then try to convince yourself that God created the whole Universe for one of the 10 million or so species of life that inhabit that speck of dust. Now take it a step further: Imagine that everything was made just for a single shade of that species, or gender, or ethnic or religious subdivision. If this doesn't strike you as unlikely, pick another dot. Imagine *it* to be inhabited by a different form of intelligent life. They, too, cherish the notion of a God who has created everything for their benefit. How seriously do you take *their* claim?

"SEE THAT STAR?"

"You mean the bright red one?" his daughter asks in return.

"Yes. You know, it might not be there anymore. It might be gone by now—exploded or something. Its light is still crossing space, just reaching our eyes now. But we don't see it as it is. We see it as it was."